

BUDDHISM

Buddhism is based on the teachings of Buddha, the “Enlightened One,” a prince who was born in India in about 563 BC. Buddha taught that suffering is always present in daily life and is caused by desiring things. Freedom from desire leads to the end of suffering and the attainment of perfect peace, or *nirvana*. Although Buddhism began in India, most Buddhists today are found elsewhere, in China, Sri Lanka, Tibet, and Southeast Asia.



Buddhist monks in Thailand in their traditional saffron colored robes – Buddhism came to Thailand from India in around the first century BC.



ANGKOR WAT

Between 880 and 1228, a city called Angkor was built by the Khmer people in what is now northwestern Cambodia. One of the most impressive buildings was a temple called Angkor Wat (pictured). Originally dedicated to the Hindu god Vishnu, it is a fusion of Hindu and Khmer art, and is spread over 200 acres (81 hectares). It consists of five towers, each thought to represent Mount Meru, the home of the gods and center of the Hindu universe. With the decline of the Khmer Empire and the rise of Buddhism in Cambodia, Angkor Wat became a Buddhist temple. Today, it is a World Heritage site, though rising numbers of tourists are causing increasing amounts of damage to it.

HINDUISM

The world’s third largest religion after Christianity and Islam, Hinduism originated in India in about 1750 BC. The word “Hindu” comes from the Persian for “India.” Today it is the dominant faith in India, Nepal, and among the Tamils of Sri Lanka. It has no single founder or scripture, though the earliest beliefs were written down in the *Vedas*, a collection of hymns and chants. Most Hindus believe in many gods but in one underlying reality (*Brahman*). They believe that when a person dies their soul is reborn in another body. People who live good lives are born again in a higher life; bad lives lead to a lower life. Devout Hindus aim to be free from the cycle of rebirth and become one with *Brahman*.



A statue of the Hindu god Shiva, the destroyer. Shiva, Brahma, and Vishnu are three of the most important gods in Hinduism.



Varanasi in India stands on the banks of the Ganges River, a holy place for Hindus.

OTHER FAITHS

CONFUCIANISM Often thought to be more like a philosophy than a religion, Confucianism was founded by Confucius, or K’ung Fu Tze, in around 500 BC. It is not based on the worship of a god but on following a moral code. Confucianism is practiced in China and other parts of east Asia.

TAOISM This faith was founded in China by Lao Tzu around 300 BC. Taoists believe in many gods and aim to live in harmony with nature. Their symbol, *Yin Yang*, stands for balance and harmony. Taoism is followed in China and other parts of east Asia.

SHINTOISM The ancient religion of Japan is based on the worship of gods of nature and ancestor worship. Most Shinto shrines are in parks, gardens, and on mountains.

JAINISM Jains do not believe in a god; their faith is based on non-violence to all living things and a belief in rebirth. Most of its followers live in India.

ZEN BUDDHISM Very important in Japan, this branch of Buddhism originated in China. It aims at harmony in living and stresses the need for meditation.

TRADITIONAL BELIEFS Around the world, there are numerous local religions handed down by word of mouth from generation to generation. Many share a belief that there are spirits living in the world – in the sky, stars, trees, lakes, and rivers. Many traditional faiths are found in Africa, where beliefs vary widely depending on the individual tribe. The ancient faith of Shamanism, found in parts of Asia, centers on a priest, or *shaman*, who goes into trances to enable people to leave their bodies and visit the spiritual world.

SIKHISM

This faith began in the Punjab region of India in the 1400s. Its founder was Guru Nanak. He was succeeded by nine other Gurus who all helped to develop Sikhism. The *Guru Granth Sahib* is the Sikh holy book. The religion is based on the worship of one God and on the cycle of human rebirth. Sikhs believe that God is found in all things, and that all people are equal in the eyes of God. Sikhism is mainly practiced in India, but followers are also found throughout the world.



The golden Palace in Amritsar, Punjab, is a site sacred to Sikhs.